FastSpeech 2 for Indian-accented English (Svarah) and Telugu (IndicTTS)

Technical report

Simhaa T. T.

November 2026

1 Summary

I trained two FastSpeech 2 models from scratch with the same architecture and recipe. The English model learnt from 4.6 h of the Svarah corpus, which holds Indian-accented English from 99 speakers. The Telugu model learnt from 4.1 h of one male voice in IndicTTS Telugu. Each language kept about 1 h of validation audio that shares no clip with training. As an ablation, I also fine-tuned a second English model from the public LJSpeech checkpoint. The code starts from the ming024 implementation, and Section 3 lists every change.

The English model speaks all five of its test sentences understandably. I do not speak Telugu, so a Telugu speech recogniser judged that audio: it made 4.7% character errors on synthesised Telugu against 3.4% on real Telugu speech, while the English recogniser made 10.0% against 6.4%. The Telugu model comes out closer to real speech on every measure I took. On 80 validation sentences, the Telugu model's predicted durations correlate with the real ones at $r = 0.85$ (English: 0.61) and its pitch at $r = 0.75$ (English: 0.43). The English spectrograms change only 63% as fast from frame to frame as real speech, against 88% for Telugu. This over-smoothing matches what the English audio sounds like: the words come out mumbled, as if swallowed. Giving the models the real pitch and energy brought their spectrograms 9% (English) and 20% (Telugu) closer to real speech, while the real durations changed almost nothing. With all prosody taken from the recording, English still stays further from real speech than Telugu, so the mumbling comes from the decoder, not from the timing. Validation loss stopped improving early in both languages, at step 14,000 for English and 12,000 for Telugu out of 60,000. Fine-tuning from LJSpeech gave slightly better English spectrograms but worse pitch and energy, and no gain overall.

2 Model

Both languages use FastSpeech 2 as implemented in `ming024/FastSpeech2`: 35.2 M parameters, 22.05 kHz audio, 80 mel bins, a 1024-point FFT and a hop of 256 samples (11.6 ms per frame).

Table 1: Architecture. Both languages share it; only English has a speaker table.

Encoder	phoneme embedding (256) + sinusoidal positions; 4 FFT blocks: 2-head self-attention, conv feed-forward (1024 filters, kernels 9 and 1), dropout 0.2
Speaker embedding	English only: a 256-d table with 99 entries, added to the encoder output
Variance adaptor	duration, pitch and energy predictors, each 2 conv layers (256 filters, kernel 3) with ReLU, LayerNorm, dropout 0.5 and a linear output. Pitch and energy take one value per phoneme, standardised per corpus, quantised into 256 linear bins and embedded (256-d) back into the hidden sequence. The length regulator uses the MFA durations in training and the rounded predicted durations at inference.
Decoder	6 FFT blocks (same settings as the encoder), a linear layer to 80 mel bins, then a 5-layer convolutional PostNet
Vocoder	pretrained universal HiFi-GAN from the ming024 release; I did not train or fine-tune it
Loss	L1 on the mel before and after the PostNet + MSE on log duration, pitch and energy (all weight 1)

Differences from the FastSpeech 2 paper. I kept three choices of the reference implementation. (1) Pitch is one F0 value per phoneme (pyworld DIO + StoneMask, unvoiced frames linearly interpolated, then averaged over the phone), not a frame-level continuous-wavelet pitch spectrogram. (2) Energy is also averaged per phoneme. (3) A PostNet follows the decoder, which the paper does not have. Per-phoneme targets carry less noise and line up with the duration predictor; the cost is that the model cannot move pitch inside a phone.

3 Changes to the reference code

The repository keeps the ming024 file layout under `core/`.

Bug fixes and updates

1. **Silences in MFA 2/3 TextGrids.** MFA 2 and 3 write silences as empty intervals, and `tgt` drops empty intervals by default. The phone durations then no longer added up to the mel length, which shifted every phone after a pause. The reader now keeps empty intervals and turns them into `sp` (`include_empty_intervals=True`); it skips utterances that contain `spn` (unknown word).
2. **Energy control.** The pitch control (`p_control`) scaled the energy predictor; the energy control (`e_control`) now does.
3. **Energy targets in float64.** ming024's `to_device` converts every target to float32 except energy, and the energy files hold float64. Plain fp32 training on a CPU tolerates this. Under CUDA mixed precision the backward pass fails (`Found dtype Double but expected Float`); both first Kaggle runs crashed on it. Energy now goes through `.float()`, and the loss casts every target to the prediction's type.
4. **CPU and worker processes.** The STFT called `.cuda()` unconditionally, which broke CPU runs and forked feature-extraction workers. It now runs on the input's device.
5. **librosa $\geq$ 0.10.** `pad_center` and `mel` need keyword arguments.
6. **Length regulator** vectorised with `torch.repeat_interleave`: same output, faster on GPU.
7. **All-zero predicted durations** now still produce one frame.
8. **Checkpoints** store the learning rate as a plain float, so `torch.load(weights_only=True)` can read them.

Additions

9. `lr_scale` in the scheduler and `--init_from` in training, for fine-tuning. Every tensor with a matching shape is copied; the phone embedding copies its overlapping rows; the pitch and energy bins come from the new data; new tensors such as the speaker table keep their random start.
10. A split file written at data selection fixes the train/validation lists, instead of a random shuffle.
11. Feature extraction runs in parallel, and each language and voice sets its own F0 search range.
12. Training: mixed precision (fp16 autocast), a full validation pass every 1,000 steps, all losses in a CSV file, best (lowest validation loss) and last checkpoints, `--resume`, and a wall-clock budget for Kaggle.
13. Inference: language-specific text front-ends. Each sentence gets a JSON file with the predicted duration (frames and ms), F0 (Hz) and energy per phone, de-normalised with the corpus statistics, and four plots.
14. **Telugu support**, which the reference code lacks: a text normaliser and a rule-based G2P (Section 3.2), and a Telugu MFA acoustic model trained on the selected corpus, because MFA has no pretrained one. The 49 Telugu phones go at the *end* of the symbol table, so the original symbols keep their indices and the LJSpeech checkpoint still loads.
15. **English front-end**: number, date and time normalisation and a split-word repair (Section 3.1).
16. Data preparation scripts for both corpora (selection, quality filters, split), and a script that builds self-contained Kaggle notebooks.

3.1 English front-end

- **Normalisation:** times (*10:45 AM → ten forty five A M*, AM/PM read as letters), dates (*12 November 2026 → twelfth November twenty twenty six*), ordinals, years and plain numbers.
- **Split-word repair:** two neighbouring tokens merge when the left piece is not a lexicon word and the merged form is (*rhyth m → rhythm*). `--no_repair` switches it off.
- **G2P order:** (1) heteronyms from the g2p_en homograph table, chosen by the NLTK part-of-speech tag (*conduct* as noun or verb); (2) acronyms of up to 4 capitals, spelled out; (3) the LibriSpeech lexicon used by ming024; (4) CMUdict; (5) the g2p_en neural model for anything left.

3.2 Telugu front-end

Telugu script is close to phonemic, so the G2P applies rules to each akshara. A consonant with a vowel sign gives C V; a consonant with virama (్) gives C, which covers conjuncts and geminates; a bare consonant keeps the inherent *a*, because Telugu does not drop it at the end of a word. The anusvara (ం) becomes the nasal that matches the next consonant (*ng, ny, nn, n, m*), or *m* at the end of a word. The visarga (ః) becomes *h*, and ఋ/ఌ become *r u*. Aspirated stops (*kh, gh, ph, bh*, ...), retroflex stops (*tt, dd, nn*) and long vowels (*aa, ii, uu, ee, oo*) are separate phones. The same G2P writes the MFA pronunciation dictionary and produces the phones at inference, so training and synthesis always agree.

The normaliser writes numbers out as Telugu words (2026 → రెండు వేల ఇరవై ఆరు), ordinals with వ (12వ → పన్నెండవ) and clock times (10:45 → పది నలభై ఐదు). Its split-word repair merges two tokens when the merged form occurs in the training transcripts and the left piece does not (అడ విలో → అడవిలో).

4 Data

4.1 English: Svarah

Svarah is an ASR test set of Indian-accented English with 117 speakers and both read and spontaneous speech. It was not built for TTS, so my selection mostly removed noisy clips and clips that would align badly. The Hugging Face copy holds 6,656 clips (9.61 h) and no speaker column. Its file-name prefix marks the recording, not the speaker (2,938 distinct values). I recovered speakers from the full metadata tuple: gender, age group, first language, state, district, education, job and domain. That gives 115 groups for 117 published speakers, so two pairs of speakers probably share a group.

Table 2: English selection funnel.

Step	Clips	Hours
Available (HF test split, 3 parquet files)	6,656	9.61
Duration 1–11 s	4,838	
Clean transcript (at least 3 words, no tags)	4,660	
SNR $\geq$ 18 dB, no clipping, $\leq$ 1.5 s edge silence	4,489	
Speakers with $\geq$ 1 min left (99 of 115)	4,354	6.26
Selected: train / validation	3,465 / 742	4.99 / 1.07
After alignment and feature extraction (silence-trimmed)	3,464 / 742	4.64 / 1.00

I drew the validation set per speaker, about one sixth of each speaker's selected audio. All 99 speakers therefore appear in both sets, but no clip does. The model needs this: it learns one embedding per speaker, and a speaker seen only in validation would have an untrained one. The SNR in Table 2 is a cheap estimate (the ratio of the 90th to the 10th percentile of 25 ms frame energies), not a measurement.

4.2 Telugu: IndicTTS

The Hugging Face copy of IndicTTS Telugu (`SPRINGLab/IndicTTS_Telugu`, 4 parquet files) holds 8,576 clips from two speakers, labelled only by gender. A single-speaker model needs one voice, so I audited both first (Table 3).

Table 3: Audit of the two IndicTTS Telugu voices. SNR is the same rough estimate as for English.

	Female	Male
Clips	4,043	4,533
Total hours	23.92	12.79
Median clip length (s)	18.5	8.3
Hours in clips of 1–11 s	1.89	6.22
of which SNR $\geq$ 25 dB	1.89	6.22
Median SNR (dB)	46.2	50.0
Sample rate	16 kHz	48 kHz

The female voice has almost twice the audio, but most of it sits in clips longer than 11 s. Long clips cost a lot of GPU memory in FastSpeech 2, because attention grows with the square of the length and a batch pads to its longest clip; they also align less reliably. I therefore kept the 1–11 s window used for English. Inside it, the female voice has 1.89 h, too little for 5 h of training, and the male voice has 6.22 h. I chose the male voice and set its F0 search range to 60–350 Hz. The sample rates differ (48 and 16 kHz), but both voices are resampled to 22.05 kHz and the mel filterbank stops at 8 kHz, so the rate did not decide anything.

Table 4: Telugu selection funnel (male voice).

Step	Clips	Hours
Available (male)	4,533	12.79
Duration 1–11 s	3,268	
Transcript in Telugu script only (no Latin letters)	3,262	
SNR $\geq$ 25 dB, no clipping	3,261	
Duplicate transcripts removed	3,256	6.20
Selected: train / validation	2,629 / 526	5.00 / 1.00
After alignment and feature extraction (silence-trimmed)	2,614 / 522	4.14 / 0.82

I shuffled the clips with a fixed seed and took the first hour as validation and the next five as training. Removing duplicate transcripts before the split keeps every sentence on one side; a check found 0 shared texts. The mean clip lasts 6.85 s in training and 6.82 s in validation.

4.3 Alignment and features

- **English:** MFA 3.4.3 aligned the clips with its pretrained `english_us_arpa` acoustic model. The dictionary combines the LibriSpeech lexicon with g2p_en pronunciations for unknown words. I widened the beams to 100/400 (defaults 10/40) because the speech is accented and partly spontaneous. All 4,207 selected clips aligned.
- **Telugu:** MFA has no pretrained Telugu model, so I trained one on the selected corpus (`mfa train --single_speaker`) with the rule-based G2P dictionary of 12,141 words; the same run produced the alignments. MFA's default recipe (monophone, triphone, LDA+MLLT, then three rounds of speaker-adapted training) took 1.85 h on 3 CPU jobs and aligned 3,136 of 3,155 clips; I dropped the 19 failures. Trimming silence removed more audio than for English (6.0 h of clips became 4.96 h of speech), because IndicTTS clips start and end with longer silences.
- **Features:** I cut leading and trailing silence at the alignment boundaries and computed mel spectrograms with the ming024 STFT. F0 comes from pyworld DIO + StoneMask (60–500 Hz for English, 60–350 Hz for Telugu), with unvoiced frames interpolated and the result averaged per phone. Energy is the L2 norm of each STFT frame, averaged per phone. The training-corpus mean and standard deviation standardise pitch and energy, after removing outliers. Pitch averages 176.3 Hz (s.d. 56.8 Hz) for English and 189.7 Hz (s.d. 42.7 Hz) for Telugu.
- **The Telugu voice is high for a man.** A wide 50–600 Hz search on 40 Telugu clips gave a median F0 of 186 Hz (10th–90th percentile 136–245 Hz), so the 60–350 Hz range cut nothing off. I listened to a clip to confirm the label: the speaker is male, with a fairly high voice.
- I stored mels as float16 for upload (largest rounding error 0.004 in log-mel units); loading converts them back to float32.

5 Training

I trained both models on Kaggle T4 GPUs (16 GB) with the settings in Table 5, which follow the ming024 LJSpeech recipe unless noted.

Table 5: Training configuration (`English/config.yaml`, `Telugu/config.yaml`).

Optimiser	Adam, $\beta = (0.9, 0.98)$, $\epsilon = 10^{-9}$, no weight decay, gradient clipping at norm 1.0
Learning rate	Noam schedule: linear warm-up over 4,000 steps to $256^{-0.5} \cdot 4000^{-0.5} \approx 9.9 \times 10^{-4}$, then $\propto \text{step}^{-0.5}$; multiplied by 0.3 at 40k, 50k and 55k steps
Batch	16 utterances, drawn from groups of 4×16 utterances sorted by length to limit padding
Steps	up to 60,000, or until the Kaggle session's time budget runs out
Precision	mixed (fp16 autocast with gradient scaling); losses computed in fp32
Validation	the full validation set every 1,000 steps; the checkpoint with the lowest total validation loss is kept
Seed	1234 (model initialisation, data order); the split file fixes the data split
Fine-tune ablation	English only: starts from the LJSpeech checkpoint (900k steps), learning rate $\times 0.5$, warm-up 1,000 steps, 30,000 steps; the speaker table and the pitch/energy bins start fresh

Table 6: What the runs did. Speed counts from step 1,000, because the first minutes include data loading.

Run	Steps	Time	Steps/min	Best step	Best val. total
English, from scratch (released)	60,000	245 min	262	14,000	2.354
English, fine-tuned from LJSpeech	30,000	134 min	253	11,000	2.369
Telugu, from scratch (released)	60,000	224 min	279	12,000	2.048

- The two English runs shared one Kaggle session, one per T4. Telugu ran alone on one T4 in a second session. All three runs reached their step limit inside the time budget.
- The LJSpeech checkpoint gave the fine-tune 231 tensors unchanged. The phone embedding kept its rows for the ARPAbet symbols, whose ids match in both models. I did not copy the pitch and energy bin edges, because they depend on the statistics of the new data.
- The fine-tune's learning-rate factor of 0.5 does not lower the peak. With a 1,000-step warm-up the Noam schedule peaks twice as high as with 4,000 steps, so the factor only brings the peak back to 9.9×10^{-4}, the same as training from scratch. The fine-tune was therefore not gentle, which may explain why little of the LJSpeech prosody survived (Section 6).

6 Loss curves

The losses are ming024's: L1 on the mel spectrogram before and after the PostNet, and MSE on log duration, standardised pitch and standardised energy; the total is their sum. Training losses go to the log every 100 steps, and validation losses cover the full validation set every 1,000 steps.

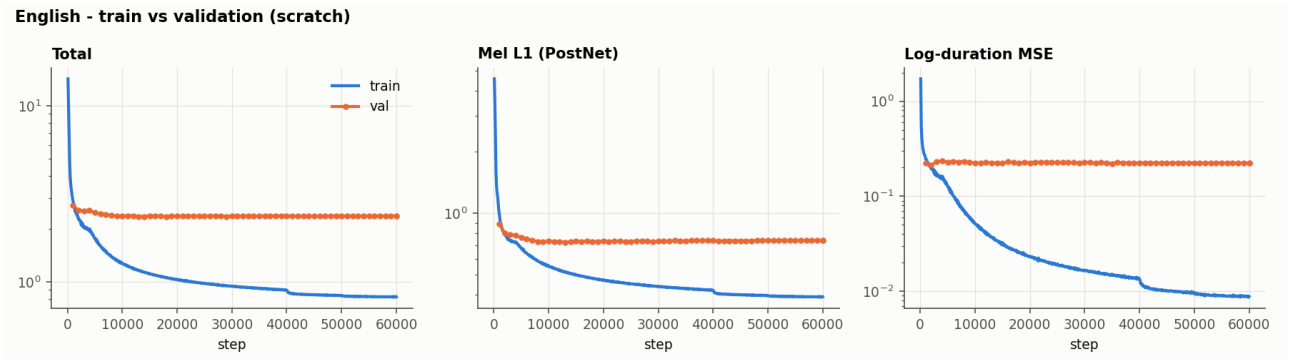


Figure 1: English, from scratch: training vs validation loss (log scale). The step at 40k is the first learning-rate drop.

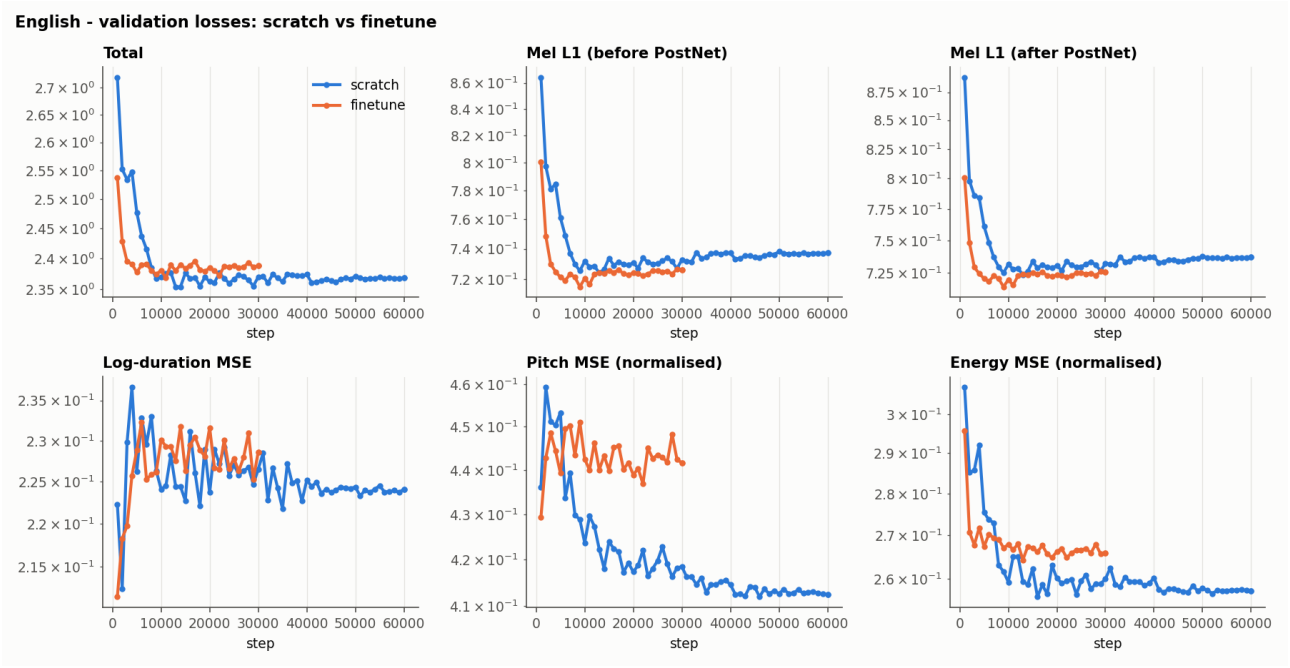


Figure 2: English validation losses, from scratch vs fine-tuned from LJSpeech.

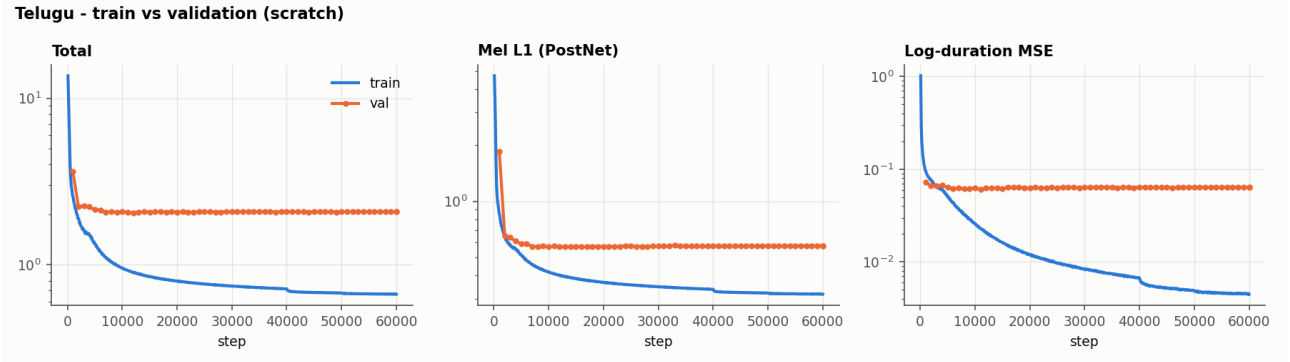


Figure 3: Telugu: training vs validation loss (log scale).

Both models stop generalising early. English validation loss falls from 2.72 at step 1,000 to its minimum of 2.354 at step 14,000. Over the remaining 46,000 steps it stays between 2.35 and 2.39, while the training loss keeps falling from 1.14 to 0.82. Telugu follows the same pattern two thousand steps sooner: validation reaches 2.048 at step 12,000 and then holds between 2.05 and 2.08, while training falls from 0.89 to 0.66. In both languages the last 46,000–48,000 steps fitted the training clips without helping on new ones. The released checkpoints come from the best steps, so they do not suffer, but three quarters of the GPU time bought nothing.

The loss terms move differently. English validation mel L1 bottoms out at step 13,000 (0.724) and then creeps up to 0.737: the decoder overfits. Validation pitch MSE keeps improving slowly until about step 46,000 (0.436 $\rightarrow$ 0.412), and energy flattens after step 16,000 at 0.256. Validation duration MSE reaches its best at step 2,000 (0.213) and never improves again, while the training duration loss falls to 0.009. The duration predictor learns average phone lengths almost at once and then memorises the training clips. Telugu's terms behave the same way, with the mel minimum at step 10,000 (0.568).

The gap between training and validation is large , above all for English duration (0.009 vs 0.224) and pitch (0.016 vs 0.413). Three causes are likely. The data is small: 4.6 h, split over 99 speakers, about

3 min each. Part of Svarah is spontaneous speech, whose timing and intonation vary in ways the phonemes cannot predict. Unseen voices are not the cause: validation uses the same 99 speakers as training.

Telugu learns duration far better, and pitch only looks worse. Duration loss is not standardised, so the two languages compare directly: Telugu reaches 0.06 and English 0.21, which means a typical duration error of $e^{0.25} \approx 1.28\times$ against $e^{0.47} \approx 1.60\times$. One voice reading prepared text times its speech far more regularly than 99 speakers partly talking freely. Telugu's validation pitch MSE (0.567) exceeds English's (0.418), but each corpus standardises pitch with its own spread. The English spread of 56.8 Hz includes the differences between 99 voices, which the speaker embedding explains for free. In Hz the root-mean-square error is $\sqrt{0.567} \times 42.7 \approx 32$ Hz for Telugu and $\sqrt{0.418} \times 56.8 \approx 37$ Hz for English.

Fine-tuning from LJSpeech helps the decoder only. The fine-tuned model starts much lower (validation total 2.54 vs 2.72 at step 1,000) and reaches a slightly lower mel loss (best 0.715 vs 0.724). Its pitch and energy losses stay higher, though: 0.440 vs 0.418 and 0.267 vs 0.259 at each run's best step. Its best total, 2.369, does not beat training from scratch (2.354). The LJSpeech start gives the decoder spectral detail, but the variance predictors gain nothing. Their bins restart from zero, and one American woman reading books does not prosodically resemble 99 Indian speakers.

7 Test sentences

The audio sits in `Results/<Language>/test_generated_audios/`. Next to the plots, a JSON file per sentence records the phones the model received and the duration, F0 and energy it predicted for each.

English (released model, speaker `en_s073`, male).

Table 7: English test sentences and what the front-end did with the hard part. Phones come from the saved JSON files.

Id	Sentence and front-end output	Length
E1	The antidisestablishmentarianism movement gained considerable momentum during the parliamentary proceedings. Neither dictionary has the long word, so g2p_en produced 26 phones (`AE2 N T AY0 D IH0 S AH0 S T AE2 B L IH0 SH M AH0 N T EH1 R IY0 AH0 N IH0 Z AH0 M`), spoken in 1.75 s.	5.34 s
E2a	The orchestra's conduct during the ceremony was praised by the audience. Noun: `K AA1 N D AH0 K T`, stress on the first syllable.	3.41 s
E2b	The researchers will conduct an experiment to evaluate the proposed method. Verb: `K AA0 N D AH1 K T`, stress on the second syllable. The part-of-speech tag tells the two readings apart.	3.63 s
E3	The rhyth m of the orchestra changed unexpectedly. The repair merges "rhyth" + "m" into the dictionary word `R IH1 DH AH0 M`. Without it (`E3_no_repair`) the model receives `R AY1 DH` + `EH1 M`, roughly "rythe em".	2.35 s
E4	The meeting will start at 10:45 AM on 12 November 2026, so andaroo should arrive on time. The normaliser produced "ten forty five AM on twelfth November twenty twenty six" and spelled AM out (`EY1 EH1 M`). "Andaroo" (Telugu for "everyone") went to g2p_en, which ended it with "oh" instead of "oo" (`AE0 N D AA1 R OW0`).	5.91 s

The English audio sounds mumbled. The speech is understandable and the sentences come out whole, but the speaker seems to swallow the words: consonants are soft and syllables run into each other. FastSpeech 2 cannot skip or repeat words the way attention-based models can, because its durations are explicit. In the whole test set only one phone received zero frames, the schwa of "-able" in "considerable" (`B AH0 L`), which speakers often drop as well because the /l/ carries the syllable. Section 8 measures the mumbling and traces it to over-smoothed spectrograms.

Telugu (released model, one male voice). The phones use the front-end's romanisation: doubled vowels are long, and `tt`, `dd`, `nn` are retroflex.

Table 8: Telugu test sentences and what the front-end did with the hard part.

Id	Sentence, meaning and front-end output	Length
T1	న్యూరోఫార్మకోలాజికల్ పరిశోధనలో నూతన ఔషధాల ప్రభావాన్ని విశ్లేషించారు. ("The effect of new drugs was analysed in neuropharmacological research.") The long loanword became 22 phones (`n y uu r oo ph aa r m a k oo l aa j i k a l`), spoken in 1.49 s. The G2P reads ఫ as aspirated `ph`, its textbook value, although many speakers say /f/ in English loanwords.	4.42 s
T2a	తాడుపై అతని పట్టు చాలా బలంగా ఉంది. ("His grip on the rope is very strong.")	2.03 s
T2b	ఆమె పట్టు చీరను ధరించి వేడుకకు వచ్చింది. ("She came to the ceremony in a silk sari.") పట్టు means "grip" in T2a and "silk" in T2b, but Telugu pronounces both the same way, so the identical phones (`p a tt tt u`) are correct.	2.37 s
T3	పులి అడ విలో నిశ్శబ్దంగా నడిచింది. ("The tiger walked silently in the forest.") The input splits అడవిలో into అడ + విలో, and the repair merges it again. The merge changes nothing: the G2P maps each akshara on its own and adds no pause between words, so both versions give the phones `a dd a v i l oo` and byte-identical audio. A split word costs nothing in Telugu's phonemic script.	1.73 s
T4	ఈ సమావేశం 2026 నవంబర్ 12వ తేదీ ఉదయం 10:45 గంటలకు ప్రారంభమవుతుంది, సమయానికి సిద్ధంగా ఉంచండి. ("This meeting starts at 10:45 a.m. on 12 November 2026; be ready on time.") The normaliser wrote the numbers as రెండు వేల ఇరవై ఆరు (2026), పన్నెండవ (12th) and పది నలభై ఐదు (10:45).	7.21 s

No Telugu phone received zero frames. The anusvara (ం) took the nasal of the following consonant, as in speech: `u n d i` (ఉంది), `b a l a ng g aa` (బలంగా) and `ny c` in విశ్లేషించారు.

I could not judge the Telugu audio by ear, because I do not speak Telugu. Speech recognisers listened instead (Section 7.1), and the measurements in Section 8 compare the predictions with real recordings of the same sentences.

7.1 Speech recognition check

Whisper base (74 M parameters) transcribed the audio. English used `openai/whisper-base.en`; Telugu used `vasista22/whisper-telugu-base`, a Whisper base model that IIT Madras fine-tuned on Telugu. A recogniser makes its own errors, so I measured a ceiling first. I took 30 random validation clips per language and turned their *real* mel spectrograms into audio with the same HiFi-GAN vocoder. The released models then synthesised the same 30 sentences from their phones, and the difference between the two error rates is what the acoustic model adds. Character error rate (CER) is the main measure. Telugu words are long, so one wrong letter fails a whole word and inflates the word error rate (WER) even for real speech.

Table 9: Recogniser error rates (%). "Real, vocoded" is the ceiling: real spectrograms through the same vocoder.

	English		Telugu	
	CER	WER	CER	WER
Real, vocoded (30 validation clips)	6.4	14.4	3.4	21.8
Synthesised, same 30 sentences	10.0	21.0	4.7	23.6
Test sentences (6 English, 5 Telugu)	26.4	56.9	3.1	20.0

Synthesised Telugu is almost as intelligible as real speech: 4.7% CER against 3.4%, a gap of 1.3 points. T1, T2a and T2b came back with every letter right; in T1 the recogniser only split the loanword into two words (న్యూరో ఫార్మకోలాజికల్). T4's numbers came back intact (రెండు వేల ఇరవై ఆరు, పది

నలభై ఐదు), and its remaining differences are spellings that sound the same (ప్రారంభం అవుతుంది for ప్రారంభమవుతుంది). T3 holds the one real error: అడవిలో నిశ్శబ్దంగా ("silently in the forest") came back as అడవిలోని శబ్దంగా. The recogniser heard one *ś* where the text has two and attached the syllable ని to the previous word. The duration predictor did not shorten the doubled consonant: it gave the two *ś* phones 105 and 93 ms, the longest consonant in the sentence. Either the vocoded audio blurs the double *ś*, or the recogniser preferred a more common word split; the data here cannot tell which.

Synthesised English loses more: 10.0% CER against 6.4% for real speech, 3.6 points, and 21.0% against 14.4% WER. On 30 clips this gap only approaches significance (Section 8.2). The larger gap matches the flux measurement in Section 8 and the mumbled sound. The test sentences fare far worse (26.4% CER), because they are built from rare words that a 74 M recogniser struggles with even when spoken clearly. I have no real recordings of them, so the table cannot separate the two causes. E2a came back almost perfectly, with only "audience" heard as "Indians". E1 became "the untetish establishment, the Zionism movement", and "momentum" became "movement". In E2b the opening "The researchers will conduct an" became "Please suggest welcome the pen". E4 lost the time, the date and "so andaroo". In E3 the recogniser heard "I don't know if" for "The rhythm of" and scored the repaired version (37.5% CER) worse than the unrepaired one (16.7%). One sentence through one recogniser cannot show whether the repair helps; the phones in Table 7 show that it gives the model the right input.

Scoring details. Svarah writes numbers as words and Whisper writes digits, so Whisper's English normaliser maps both sides to digits before scoring. Whisper's basic normaliser cannot score Telugu: it deletes Unicode combining marks, which in Telugu are the vowel signs and the virama, and would compare bare consonants. For Telugu I removed only punctuation. I also raised the output limit to 440 tokens, because Telugu needs many tokens per word and the default cut long sentences short. `Results/<Language>/logs/asr_check.json` holds every transcript, and `tools/` holds the scripts.

8 Variance adaptor predictions

Every test sentence has four plots in `Results/<Language>/variance_adaptor_plots/`: predicted duration per phone, F0 per phone in Hz, energy per phone, and an overview that stacks the generated mel spectrogram over F0 and energy on one time axis (Figures 4 and 5).

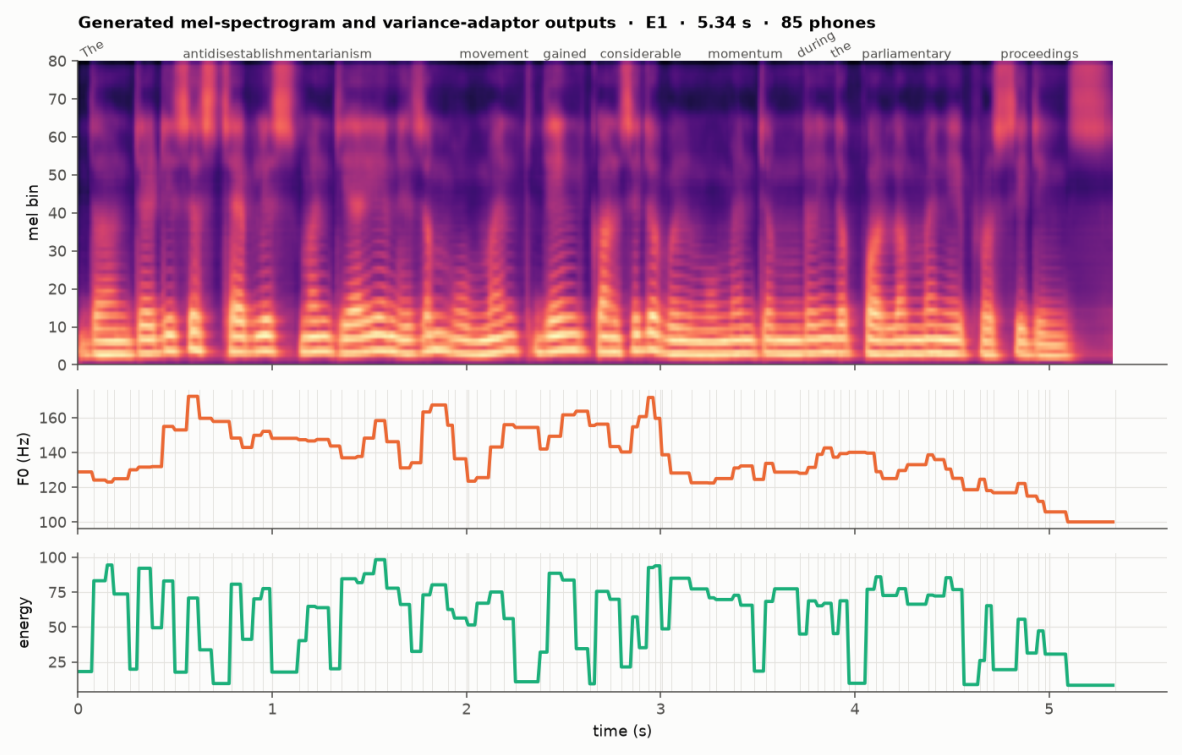


Figure 4: English E1: generated mel spectrogram with the predicted F0 and energy per phone.

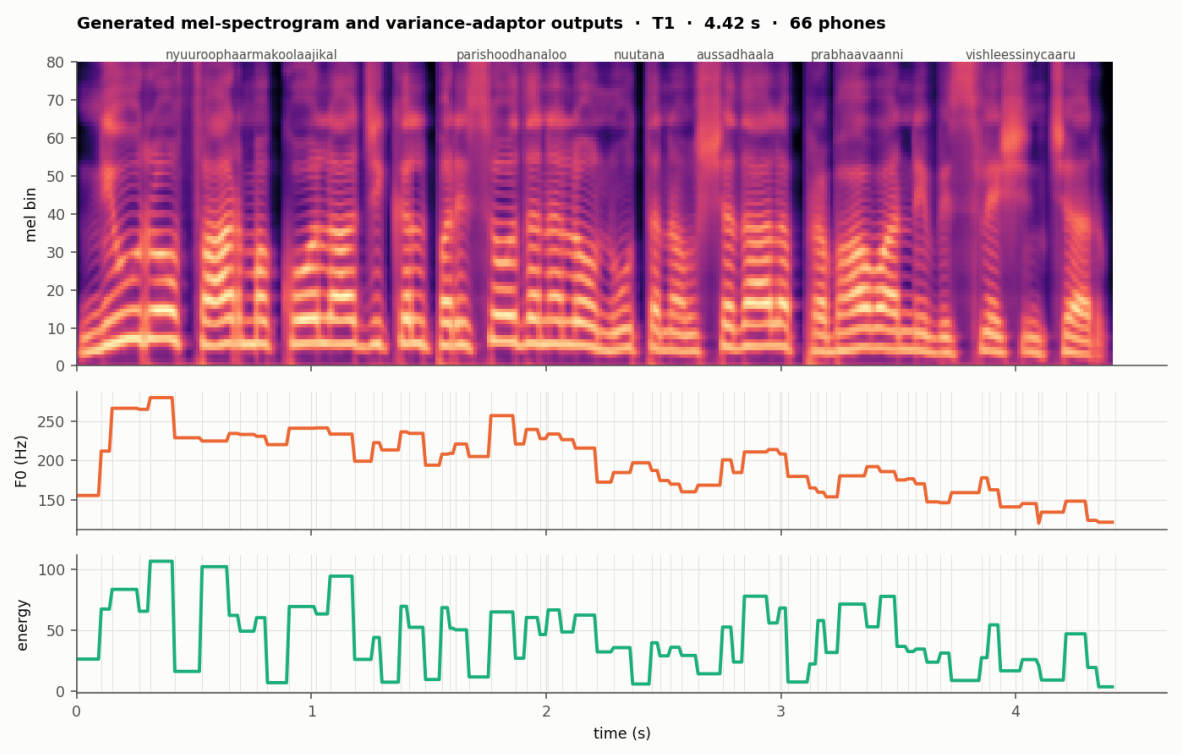


Figure 5: Telugu T1. Matplotlib cannot shape Telugu script, so the word labels show the romanised phones.

8.1 Against real speech

Test sentences have no recording to compare with, so I ran the released models on 80 random validation clips per language and compared each prediction with the real features of the same clip. The model received the clip's phones, including the pauses that MFA found, and predicted everything else itself. Pre-

dicted and real durations differ, so I compare utterance-level statistics, not frames.

Table 10: Predictions on 80 validation clips per language against the real features of the same clips (medians). A spread ratio is predicted SD / real SD within an utterance, so 1.0 means the same spread. Global variance is the per-mel-bin variance over time; flux is the mean absolute change between neighbouring frames.

	English	English fine-tuned	Telugu
Pitch spread ratio	0.67	0.75	0.85
Energy spread ratio	0.96	0.98	0.94
Pitch correlation (per phone)	0.43	0.39	0.75
Energy correlation (per phone)	0.82	0.82	0.92
Log-duration correlation (per phone)	0.61	0.61	0.85
Predicted / real length	0.96	0.99	0.97
Mel global variance, predicted / real	0.85	0.88	0.97
Mel flux, predicted / real	0.63	0.61	0.88

Flux measures the mumbling. A real English spectrogram changes from one frame to the next 1.6 times as much as the predicted one (flux ratio 0.63). Transitions between sounds therefore blur: a stop's burst, the jump from consonant to vowel, the movement of a formant. That is what "swallowed" words sound like. The L1 mel loss causes it. When several spectrograms fit the same phones, the loss rewards their middle, and the middle of several sharp transitions is one soft one. Telugu loses much less (0.88), because one speaker's read speech leaves fewer plausible spectrograms to average. The fine-tune keeps more overall variance (0.88) but not sharper transitions (0.61); LJSpeech gave the decoder detail, not crispness.

Intonation comes out flat in English. The English model's pitch varies two thirds as much as the real pitch inside an utterance (0.67), and follows its shape only loosely ($r = 0.43$). Averaging explains the flatness again: when the text does not decide whether a phrase rises or falls, the safest prediction stays near the mean. Telugu keeps 85% of the real spread and tracks the contour well ($r = 0.75$). Energy follows the real values closely in both languages ($r = 0.82$ and 0.92) with nearly the right spread, because energy depends mostly on which phone is spoken: vowels are loud and stops quiet.

Both models speak slightly fast. Given the same phones, they produce 3–4% less time than the real speaker took. The duration correlation repeats the loss curves: 0.85 for Telugu, 0.61 for English.

8.2 Which prediction costs the most?

Table 10 shows how the predictions differ from real speech, not what each difference costs. To measure that, I gave the released models the real values from the recording in place of their own predictions, one part at a time, on the same 30 validation clips as Section 7.1. Every version went through the same HiFi-GAN and the same recogniser. Two further measures compare each version with the real recording: mel-cepstral distortion (MCD), the distance between the generated and the real spectrogram, and the root-mean-square F0 error in cents (100 cents make a semitone).

Table 11: Real values in place of predictions, on 30 validation clips per language (means). "Real, vocoded" is the recording's own spectrogram through the vocoder; MCD and F0 error use it as the reference.

	English			Telugu		
Duration / pitch and energy	CER %	MCD dB	F0 cents	CER %	MCD dB	F0 cents
Predicted / predicted (normal)	10.0	3.05	310	4.7	2.55	316
Real / predicted	12.3	3.05	302	3.8	2.50	298
Predicted / real	10.0	2.78	202	3.7	2.04	119
Real / real	11.5	2.81	180	4.2	1.98	116
Real, vocoded	6.4	–	–	3.4	–	–

Pitch and energy cost the most; durations cost almost nothing. Real pitch and energy cut MCD by 0.27 dB in English (9%) and 0.51 dB in Telugu (20%), and the F0 error by 108 and 198 cents. Real durations moved MCD by 0.00 and 0.05 dB and the F0 error by 8 and 18 cents. A paired bootstrap over the 30 clips (5,000 resamples) puts the pitch-and-energy gains far from zero: the 95% interval for the English MCD gain runs from 0.18 to 0.36 dB. The duration gains stay within 0.1 dB of zero in both languages. The English duration predictor's weak correlation ($r = 0.61$) therefore costs little: with the real timing, the decoder makes spectrograms of the same quality.

The English decoder sets the floor. With every prosody value taken from the recording, English still reaches only 2.81 dB, against 1.98 dB for Telugu. What remains comes from the decoder, the part that turns phones and prosody into a spectrogram. Real prosody does not close the gap between the languages; it widens it, from 0.50 dB with predictions to 0.83 dB with real values, because Telugu gains more from real pitch than English does. The mumbled English sound therefore comes from the decoder, not from the timing, and real durations do not remove it. The first two improvements in Section 9 target exactly this part.

Pitch stays off even when it is real. With the real pitch, the F0 error still comes to 180 cents in English and 116 in Telugu. The model receives one pitch value per phone, so it cannot reproduce the rise or fall inside a phone. English adds noisier recordings, which make F0 harder to extract on both sides: even with everything real, the generated and the real audio disagree on whether a frame is voiced in 22% of English frames against 13% of Telugu frames.

The recogniser cannot separate the versions. No English version differs from the normal system by more than the noise: every 95% interval spans zero and covers 6 to 7 points. In Telugu, real pitch and energy lowered CER by 1.1 points (interval 0.2 to 2.0), but with real durations added the gain shrank to 0.5 and lost significance, so I read no pattern into it. Thirty clips can resolve a difference of about 1 point in Telugu and only about 3 in English. The same caution applies to Table 9. Telugu's 1.3-point gap between real and synthesised speech holds (interval 0.3 to 2.5), but English's 3.5-point gap does not quite (interval -0.4 to 7.3).

Method details. MCD uses cepstral coefficients 1 to 24 of the 80-band log-mel spectrogram, averaged over DTW-aligned frames, silences included. It compares the model's spectrogram before the vocoder. Other papers usually compute MCD from WORLD or SPTK spectral envelopes, so these absolute values compare versions within this report, not with published numbers. I aligned every version with DTW, even when the lengths matched, so the versions with real durations face the same alignment as the rest. F0 comes from WORLD (DIO with StoneMask) on the vocoded audio, scored against the vocoded real spectrogram so that the vocoder affects both sides equally, over frames voiced in both. `Results/<Language>/ablation_samples/` holds three of the clips in all five versions for listening, and `logs/ablation.json` holds every number and transcript.

8.3 In the test sentences

- **Declination.** F0 falls through every sentence, as it does in natural statements. The mean F0 of the last third of the vowels lies below that of the first third in all ten sentences: by 15–24 Hz in English (for example 145 → 122 Hz in E2a) and by 16–73 Hz in Telugu (236 → 163 Hz in T1).
- **Pauses at commas.** E4 and T4 each contain a comma, and the front-end turns it into a pause token. The duration predictor gave those pauses 360 ms (E4) and 314 ms (T4), a natural length for a clause break. The other eight sentences have no internal punctuation and got no pauses.
- **Stress in "conduct" (E2a vs E2b).** The model marks the first syllable as the heteronym table intends. Stressed in the noun, its vowel lasts 58 ms at 140 Hz with energy 73; unstressed in the verb, it lasts 35 ms at 133 Hz with energy 56. The second syllable follows only in loudness: the verb's stressed `AH1` is louder than the noun's unstressed `AH0` (76 vs 68), but shorter (46 vs 93 ms) and lower (120 vs 130 Hz). The model has learnt the stress contrast on the first syllable and only part of it on the second.
- **Final lengthening appears in four sentences of ten.** The last word's vowels last longer than the sentence's average vowel in E3, E4, T2a and T4 (for example 104 vs 60 ms in E4), but not in the other six.
- **Speaking rate** lies between 14.2 and 15.9 phones per second in English and between 14.9 and 17.9 in Telugu.

9 English vs Telugu, limitations and improvements

Telugu wins on every measure. Telugu has a lower validation loss (2.048 vs 2.354), better duration and pitch tracking (Table 10), spectrograms closer to real speech in both variance and flux, and a smaller intelligibility loss against real speech (1.3 vs 3.6 CER points, Table 9). The data explains this better than the language does. The Telugu model hears one speaker for 4.1 h of read, studio-quality speech. The English model hears 99 speakers for about 3 minutes each, part of it spontaneous, recorded for ASR testing rather than synthesis. Telugu's phonemic script also helps: the rule-based G2P has no unknown words, while English needed g2p_en guesses for 1,158 words of its training dictionary and for "andaroo" at test time.

Limitations.

- **Over-smoothed English spectrograms** (flux ratio 0.63) make the speech sound mumbled. The decoder causes this, not the prosody predictions (Section 8.2).
- **Flat English intonation** (pitch spread ratio 0.67, $r = 0.43$).
- **Wasted training:** both models peaked by step 14,000 of 60,000.
- **Speaker identity in English rests on a guess:** 115 metadata groups for 117 real speakers.
- **Loanwords:** the Telugu G2P reads ఫ as `ph` where speakers often say /f/, and the English front-end mispronounces Telugu words such as "andaroo".
- **One pitch value per phone** cannot express a rise or fall inside a long vowel.
- **No listening test:** English quality rests on my own listening, and Telugu quality on a speech recogniser and the measures in Table 10, because I do not speak Telugu. A recogniser measures whether words survive, not whether speech sounds natural. A mean opinion score from several native listeners of each language would settle both.

Improvements, in the order I would try them.

1. **Fine-tune HiFi-GAN on this model's outputs.** Running the trained FastSpeech 2 with the real durations gives predicted mels aligned to real audio; training the vocoder on those pairs teaches it

to restore the detail the acoustic model smooths away. The HiFi-GAN authors fine-tune on Tacotron 2 outputs in the same way. This attacks the mumbling directly and needs no new data.

2. **Add an adversarial loss on the mel spectrogram.** A discriminator penalises the averaged, blurred spectrograms that L1 rewards; this targets the flux deficit in Table 10.
3. **Give English fewer speakers with more audio each**, for example the 20 speakers with the most clean read speech. Three minutes per voice is too little to learn a voice's timing and intonation.
4. **Stop early.** Ending a run once validation loss has not improved for 10,000 steps would have cut training to about 24,000 steps, 40% of the GPU time.
5. **Fine-tune from LJSpeech with a truly low learning rate** (peak around 10^{-4}), so that the pre-trained decoder keeps what it knows.
6. **Add loanword rules**: $\eth \rightarrow$ /f/ in recognised English loanwords, and a Telugu-to-ARPAbet mapping for Telugu words in English text.

10 Reproducibility

Software. Python 3.11 for data preparation and 3.13 on Kaggle; PyTorch 2.11 with CUDA 12.8 on Kaggle and a CPU build for data preparation; librosa 0.11; pyworld; soundfile; soxr; tgt; g2p_en 2.1.0 with NLTK (`averaged_perceptron_tagger(_eng)`, `cmudict`); inflect; pandas; pyarrow; matplotlib. `requirements.txt` lists them all. Montreal Forced Aligner 3.4.3 runs in its own conda environment (`core/prep/mfa.sh setup`). Its PostgreSQL server refuses to run as root, so the script runs MFA as an unprivileged user `mfa`. MFA 3.4 has no `--beam` flag, so the beams go through a YAML file.

Configuration. `English/config.yaml` and `Telugu/config.yaml` hold everything that affects the results: selection thresholds, feature settings, model size, optimiser and steps. The prepared data keeps the copies actually used (`config_used.yaml`). `split.tsv` fixes the data split, and seed 1234 fixes selection and training. GPU training still differs slightly between runs, because some CUDA kernels are non-deterministic and fp16 rounds differently.

Commands. From the repository root:

```
pip install -r requirements.txt
sudo bash core/prep/mfa.sh setup                        # MFA 3.4.3 (+ user "mfa")
# data selection -> MFA alignment -> features
sudo python English/preprocess.py --stage all --hf_dir <svarah parquet dir>
sudo python Telugu/preprocess.py  --stage all --hf_dir <indictts parquet dir> --gender male
# training (best + last checkpoints, CSV losses in work/<Lang>/logs)
python English/train.py
python Telugu/train.py
# test sentences -> Results/<Lang>/{test_generated_audios, variance_adaptor_plots}
python English/inference.py --speaker en_s073
python Telugu/inference.py
python Telugu/inference.py --no_repair --suffix _no_repair --only T3
# loss plots + fp16 release checkpoints
python core/export.py --lang English --runs scratch:work/English/logs \
                      --ckpt_dirs scratch:English/checkpoints
python core/export.py --lang Telugu --runs scratch:work/Telugu/logs \
                      --ckpt_dirs scratch:Telugu/checkpoints
```

The Kaggle notebooks in `kaggle/` run the same commands, and `kaggle/build_notebooks.py` rebuilds them with the current code embedded. The scripts in `tools/` produce every evaluation in Sections 7.1 and 8:

`asr_eval.py` and `asr_rescore.py` the recogniser check, `variance_eval.py` Table 10, and `ablation_eval.py` with `ablation_ci.py` Table 11 and its intervals. Each script's header gives its arguments. They need `transformers` and `jiwer` on top of `requirements.txt`.

Checks. `tools/sanity_checks.py` tests four things that could go wrong without any error message; all four passed.

- **Features match the audio.** In all 7,342 clips (3,136 Telugu, 4,206 English) the phone durations add up exactly to the mel length, and pitch, energy and duration each hold one value per phone. A mismatch would shift every feature after it, which is what the TextGrid silence bug did before the fix.
- **The released checkpoints are the logged ones.** The training code's own validation function, run on CPU in fp32 over the full validation set, gives 2.0482 for the Telugu fp16 checkpoint (logged 2.0481) and 2.3540 for English (logged 2.3540). Validation runs with dropout off and without gradients.
- **The learning rate follows the schedule.** The logged values match the Noam formula with the three drops: 2.47×10^{-5} at step 100 and 6.89×10^{-6} at step 60,000.
- **The speaker table changes the voice.** Speaker `en_s073` has a median F0 of 127 Hz in the training data and 131 Hz in the synthesised test sentences; speaker `en_s034` has 209 Hz in both.

Checkpoints. `<Lang>/checkpoints/best_model_fp16.pth.tar` holds the weights with the lowest validation loss in fp16. At about 70 MB each they stay under GitHub's 100 MB file limit, so Git LFS is not needed. The normalisation statistics, speaker map and vocabulary that inference needs sit next to each checkpoint. The trained Telugu MFA acoustic model is in `Telugu/mfa_model/`.